How to Get Better at the Things You Care About

1. According to the author, why do many people fail to improve even though they work hard?
A. They lack natural talent.
B. They spend too much time in the learning zone.
C. They spend almost all their time in the performance zone.
D. They don't get enough feedback from others.

2. What is the main goal when someone is in the learning zone?
A. To demonstrate mastery and avoid mistakes.
B. To improve by focusing on areas not yet mastered.
C. To compete with others and measure progress.
D. To perform at the highest possible level.

3. Which of the following best describes "deliberate practice"?
A. Repeating the same activity until it feels natural.
B. Practicing only the parts you already do well.
C. Working on specific subskills with full focus and feedback.
D. Practicing without guidance to build independence.

4. What does the example of Demosthenes mainly illustrate?
A. The importance of talent over hard work.
B. How deliberate and creative practice leads to mastery.
C. The value of focusing only on performance.
D. The dangers of overtraining in one skill.

5. Why does the author say high-stakes environments can limit growth?
A. They make people compete harder and improve faster.
B. They encourage too much reflection instead of action.
C. They create fear of mistakes, preventing experimentation.
D. They reward innovation more than consistency.

6. What is one strategy the author suggests for creating "low-stakes islands"?
A. Taking on extra work without supervision.
B. Having feedback-oriented meetings or trusted mentors.
C. Avoiding collaboration and working independently.
D. Competing with colleagues to test new skills.

7. What is the author's overall message about improvement and performance?
A. Focusing only on performance leads to long-term success.
B. Improvement happens naturally through experience.
C. Alternating intentionally between learning and performing leads to excellence.
D. It's better to perform constantly and learn from mistakes afterward.

Answer the questions:

1. What do the best chess players do?
   Analyse other grandmasters' games.
2. What's the way to high performance?
   Deliberate practice – breaking overall issue into small factors and focusing on those which need improvement the most.
3. What is the connection between: Demosthenes – sword – stones / Beyoncé – video of the show – next day - notes
   Both blur the lines between zones, Demosthenes made learning zone a high – stake environment and Beyonce used her performance from performance zone in learning zone practices.

Fill the gaps with the words below:

Most people work hard at the things that *matter* to them, like school, work, or relationships, but often find themselves not *improving* as much as they'd like. Research and experience show that simply working hard isn't always enough to get better. The most effective people *alternate* between two important "zones": the *performance* zone and the *learning* zone.

The learning zone is where your goal is to improve. In this zone, you focus on what you haven't *mastered* yet, practice deliberately, make mistakes, get *feedback*, and try again. The performance zone is where your goal is to do your *best* and use what you already know, *minimizing* mistakes. Most people spend too much time in the performance zone and not enough time in the learning zone, which *limits* improvement.

Historical and modern examples, like the orator Demosthenes or performer Beyoncé, show that real *growth* comes from deliberate, focused practice in the learning zone. Creating safe, low-stakes *opportunities* for practice, seeking feedback, reflecting, and having a growth mindset are key ways to keep improving. *Balancing* time between learning and performing – and knowing when to be in each zone – leads to ongoing growth and better results in the long term.

PERFORMANCE FEEDBACK OPPORTUNITIES MASTERED
BALANCING LIMITS ALTERNATE GROWTH MINIMIZING
LEARNING IMPROVING BEST MATTER

1. What is the difference between the Learning Zone and Performance Zone?
   Performance zone expects you to give your best, learning zone wants you to focus on your worst.
2. What happens once we think we have become good enough?
   We get stuck in the performance zone.
3. What should we spend more time doing?
   Improving our flaws by deliberate practice.
4. Describe a time when you were in the learning zone. What did you do to try to improve?
   While playing the clarinet I stumbled upon a note on the score that was too high for me to perform. Instead of practicing the whole piece, I focused on exercises targeted for achieving said high sound.

5. Why is it important to have both a learning zone and a performance zone in your life?
   Performance zone is the zone we draw the most enjoyment from. If we were to stick only to the learning zone there wouldn't be a point in learning a skill.
6. What are some ways you could create "low-stakes" situations to practice and get better at something important to you?
   Individualising otherwise socialized tasks. For example in schools, asking kids to check the answers with their peers puts less pressure on them than calling them out in front of an entire class.